The Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Great Club

Āryamahādaṇḍanāmadhāraṇī · Toh 958 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་ཏ་ཅོན་ཆེན་པ་ཞེས་བྱ་བ་ཟླའ་གཟུངས།

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Great Club, known in Sanskrit as the Āryamahādaṇḍanāmadhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Phakpa Bechön Chenpo Zhejawé Zung, is a short protective scripture belonging to the class of dhāraṇī texts, the incantations and formulas of power that the Buddhist tradition regards as safeguards against harm. It opens with the Buddha dwelling on Vulture Peak near Rājagṛha with a great assembly of monks, while his son, the venerable Rāhula, stays in the Cool Grove charnel ground and is severely afflicted by a host of seizing spirits, including devas, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, and pretas, as well as by dangerous animals and stinging creatures. This setting frames the teaching of the dhāraṇī as a remedy, a "great club" for driving away such spirits and dangers. The work is Toh 958 in the Kangyur, where it is counted among the dhāraṇī texts gathered in the canon.

In the language of India: ārya mahā daṇḍa nāma dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Great Club.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak, together with a great Saṅgha of twelve hundred and fifty monks. At that time the venerable Rāhula was staying in the great charnel ground of Rājagṛha called the Cool Grove (Śītavana), in a spot resembling a great heap of firewood. There he was severely tormented by deva grahas, asura grahas, nāga grahas, yakṣa grahas, rākṣasa grahas, kinnara grahas, mahoraga grahas, gandharva grahas, human grahas, Vāyu grahas, preta grahas, bhūta grahas, piśāca grahas and kumbhāṇḍa grahas, by leopards, crows, owls, ants and beetles, scorpions and snakes, and by other beings as well, human and nonhuman.

Then the venerable Rāhula went to Vulture Peak, where the Blessed One was. When he arrived, he bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and wept before him, shedding tears.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Rāhula, "Rāhula, why are you sitting before me shedding tears?"

When he had said this, the venerable Rāhula replied to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, while I was staying in the great charnel ground of Rājagṛha, the Cool Grove, in a spot resembling a great heap of firewood, I was severely tormented there by deva grahas, asura grahas, nāga grahas, yakṣa grahas, rākṣasa grahas, kinnara grahas, gandharva grahas, mahoraga grahas, human grahas, Vāyu grahas, preta grahas, bhūta grahas, piśāca grahas and kumbhāṇḍa grahas, by leopards, crows, owls, ants and beetles, scorpions and snakes, and by other beings as well, human and nonhuman."

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Rāhula, "Rāhula, take up this vidyā-mantra of the Great Club Dhāraṇī, which brings protection, safeguarding and shelter, lasting benefit, help and happiness to the four assemblies: monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen.

tadyathā aṅgā baṅgā taṅgā taraṅgā sarā sarā taraṅgāsva sadadasa jadharā akkere ara bīrā tara bīrā kara bīrā karkara bīrā curu bīrā curu curu bīrā indra indraki sarahanasa hanaskisara micirelā maha miccha bahā miccha bañiṣīkā kalicchakā aṅge jaye jayelikā āelā cinta lile tile tile sumati busumati culunaṭṭe culu culu naṭṭe culanaṭe kunaṭe harīṭaki narīṭakita gauri gantrāri dhāraṇi dhāraṇe uṣṭa bipīlika uṣṭa bapilake karā karṭhike kākeli calanaṭṭi kagimali lamati rakṣamati pālakukhi batasale unmile tara bīre tara tara bīre kuru bīre kuru kuru bīre curu bīre curu bīre curu curu bīre mahā bīre iramati baramati rakṣamati sarba artha sādhani baramasura sādhani apratihate

King Indra, King Candra, King Yama, King Vāyu, King Manasvin, the son of King Vāsuki, King Daṇḍa, King Adaṇḍa, King Brahmā, Possessor of the Thousand, and the Buddha, the Blessed One, lord of Dharma, king of Dharma, through your unsurpassed compassion for the whole world, please protect me! Please thoroughly safeguard me, take me fully into your care, and fully sustain me; bring peace and well-being; avert punishment, avert weapons, kill poison, neutralize poison, seal the boundaries, and bind the ground!

tadyathā ilamele tasalā iramati biramati calamati phurumati phuru phuru phuru phuru barkhururu khurumati bhūmibaṇṭe kalike caṇḍali akisarāle iyāsā salamatohule sthule śalejaya sthule calanāṭi calanāṭi nāganandhāraṇī goraheṇi gole hihe aṇḍare paṇḍare keyūre ketumati bhūtaṃgame bhūtabate dharye mahābale acunḍe acurunade dharandhara jayalikā jale gorohāni cara huru huru rundhu rundhu huru dhumati dharandhare dhare biśvamati nāśani bandhani mocani bimocani sādhani śodhani biśodhani saṃgiraṇi maṃthīraṇi acchintani sadhutaramāne hara hara bandhumati hiri hiri gelirile huru huru

piṅgale svāhā

Homage to the buddhas, the blessed ones!

"Rāhula, if this hundred-and-tenfold vidyā-mantra of the Great Club Dhāraṇī is knotted onto a thread and tied on the arm or around the neck, then that person will be protected all around, for a circuit of ten yojanas, by clubs, by flowers and by mudrās. Humans and nonhumans will be unable to harm him. He will not meet his death through weapons, poison, illness, epidemic disease, virulent fever, spells, vetālas, wrathful malevolent beings, fire or water.

"It brings to accomplishment even those properly performed applications of vidyā-mantras and secret mantras that have not been accomplished. It keeps those that have been accomplished from going to waste. It binds the rites of others. It frees from bonds imposed by others.

"It destroys illness, sorrow and obstructors. It thoroughly pacifies the turmoil of quarrels. It turns back all grahas. Whatever graha disregards it, its head will split into seven pieces, like a sprig of arjaka. Vajrapāṇi, the great general of the yakṣas, also, his vajra blazing, all ablaze, blazing fiercely all around, become a single tongue of flame, splits its head into seven pieces like a sprig of arjaka. The Four Great Kings also destroy it with weapons, iron wheels like razor edges. When it has died and passed from that world of the yakṣas, it will not obtain a dwelling in the retinue of the palace of Alakāvatī.

"Rāhula, whoever has gone among kings, bandits, fire, water, weapons, wild lands, forests, mountains or deserts, and recites this vidyā-mantra of the dhāraṇī of the Great Club even once, will be completely freed from all evil.

"Rāhula, this dhāraṇī-mantra of the Great Club has been spoken, is spoken, and will be spoken by buddhas, blessed ones, as numerous as the grains of sand in ninety-one Ganges rivers. It is supremely accomplished, invincible by others, praised by gods, nāgas, gandharvas and others, and upheld by all bhūtas. May I and all sentient beings be safe from all harm! May we be free from illness and free from fear!"

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Rāhula rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the noble Great Vehicle dhāraṇī called the Great Club.

It was translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the chief editor and translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, and was then revised and finalized according to the new terminology.

Translator's Notes

• The phrase "in a spot resembling a great heap of firewood" renders an unusual expression. It may instead describe Rāhula himself sitting motionless like a great log. The Tibetan word for "torment" is partly illegible in the source at its first occurrence, so it is read from the parallel later in the passage. The kings named "Club" and "Clubless" are rendered Daṇḍa and Adaṇḍa on the basis of the Sanskrit title, where the same Tibetan word renders daṇḍa. The king rendered Candra ("Moon") could also stand for Soma. "Brahmā, Possessor of the Thousand" is translated literally because the Sanskrit epithet could not be identified with confidence; it may refer to Brahmā as lord of a thousandfold world system. In "avert punishment," the word elsewhere glossed as "annihilation" plainly means punishment in this context. "Hundred-and-tenfold" translates a numerical qualifier of the vidyā-mantra, and the text does not say whether it counts syllables or phrases.
• The verb rendered "disregards" literally means "lets go of" or "abandons." In context it most likely means a graha that ignores or defies the dhāraṇī. The image of a head splitting "like a sprig of arjaka" is the standard simile for this punishment. Alakāvatī is the city of Kubera, the lord of the yakṣas.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.